

Publish, not Perish: Demystifying the Submission and Peer Review Process

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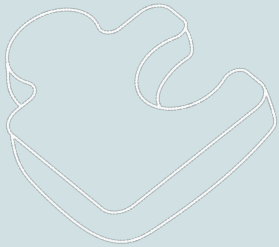


Agenda

1. Journal Selection: Strategies for Submission
2. What is Peer Review?
3. The Process and The Problems
4. Isn't There a Better Way to Do This?
5. Hacking Peer Review



1. Journal Selection: Strategies for Submission



Journal Selection: Strategies



- Consult disciplinary journal guides - [JournalGuide](#)
- Review reference lists and bibliographies
- Use academic journal indices
- Talk to colleagues/mentors
- Check university department websites

Journal Selection: Key areas of focus

- **Scope**
- Peer Review, and the kind of peer review
- Journal Impact Factor - Journal Citation Reports
 - Most frequently cited journals in a field
 - Highest impact journals in a field
 - Reliable middle-tier journals in a field

- Format and Circulation
- Acceptance Rate
- Editorial Timeline
- Charges for processing or extra pages
- Access - now and in the future

Querying

short inquiries designed to determine whether the editor of a particular journal is interested in your topic and approach

- Not all journals welcome queries
- Response times vary
- Tweak your query and submit many

<https://www.aje.com/en/arc/how-to-write-presubmission-inquiry-academic-journal/>

Sample pre-submission inquiry

Dear Dr. Jones,

I'm writing to inquire about the suitability of my paper, "[*full paper title*]" for *Journal of Quality Science*. I believe that the results we present would be a good fit for your readers, and I hope you will consider evaluating the manuscript to see if it falls within your journal's scope. Our title, and abstract are copied below. I have also attached the full manuscript, in case you or another editor would like to read further.

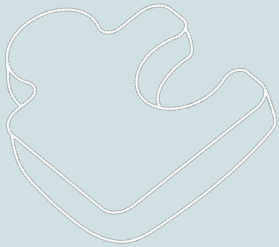
Specifically, we have shown [*key finding*] using [*primary method*]. These results fit nicely with *Journal of Quality Science*'s aim of publishing works on [*related aspect of journal's aims and scope*]. If you have any questions about the manuscript, please let me know.

Thank you very much, and I look forward to your reply.

Best regards,

[*your name and institutional affiliation*]

2. What is Peer Review?



What is Peer Review?

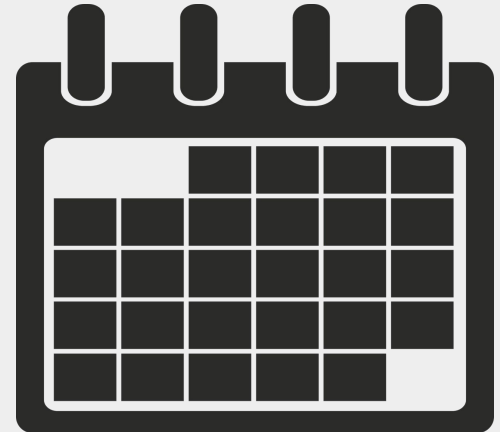
“[Peer review is] a process where scientists (“peers”) evaluate the quality of other scientists’ work. By doing this, they aim to ensure the work is rigorous, coherent, uses past research and adds to what we already knew.”

- [The Conversation](#)



History of Peer Review

- Most of what we now know as codified peer review began forming in the 1950s and was standard practice by the 1980s
- Evolved as effort to manage content and publication process
- Editorial role - from managing content to managing reviewers
- A longer and more laborious process

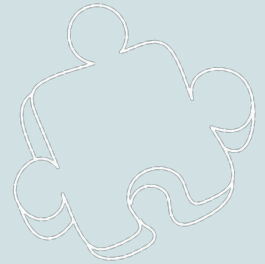


Common Elements of Peer Review

- 1) **Blind/Double Blind Review** - Reviewers with known expertise in the field are asked to weigh in. Need to disclaim conflicts of interest first.
- 2) **Exclusive Submission** - As an author you grant that the paper is submitted to only one journal at a time
- 3) **Revise and Resubmit** - If paper is not rejected, you'll have an opportunity to address concerns outlined by the reviewers



3. Why Peer Review?

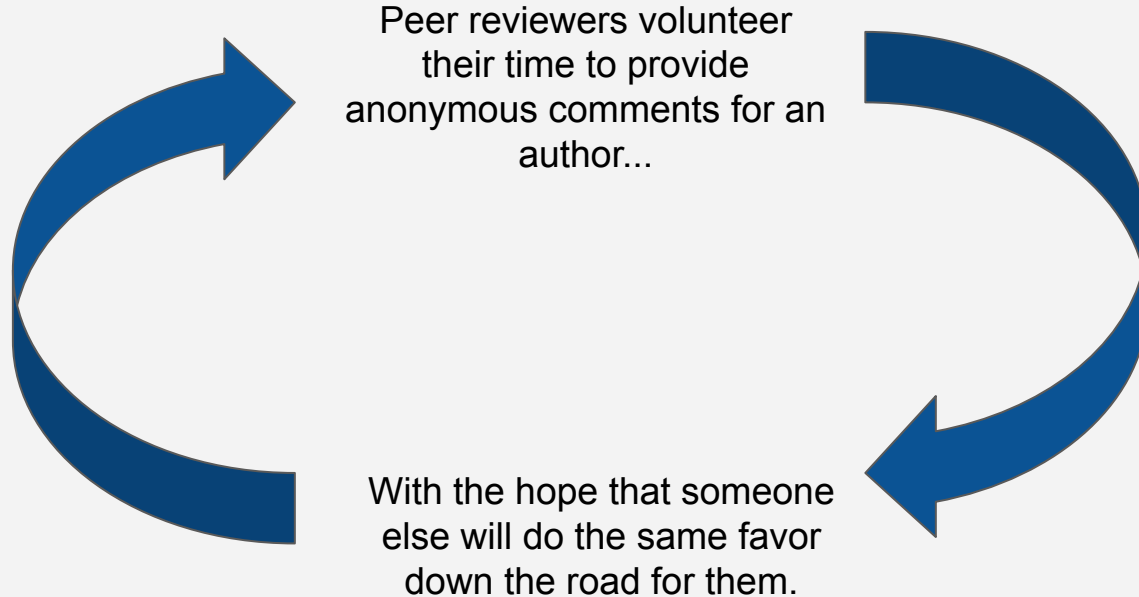


Advantages of Peer Review

- 1) Rigor
- 2) Anonymity
- 3) Feedback
- 4) Levels the playing field



Peer review is a karmic process



● June 12, 2022

The Peer-Review Crisis

The peer-review system, which relies on unpaid volunteers, has long been stressed. COVID-19 has made it worse. Possible solutions include paying reviewers or limiting revise-and-resubmits. Are these Band-Aids on structural problems?

By Colleen Flaherty

<https://www.insidehighered.com/news/2022/06/13/peer-review-crisis-creates-problems-journals-and-scholars>



October 24, 2023

AI and Peer Review: Enemies or Allies?

Amid bans and restrictions on their use, artificial intelligence tools are creating interest among those who see a solution to systemic peer-review woes.

By Lauren Coffey

<https://www.insidehighered.com/news/tech-innovation/artificial-intelligence/2023/10/24/ai-can-lessen-peer-review-woes-researchers>

4. The process and the problems



When are you ready to submit for peer review?

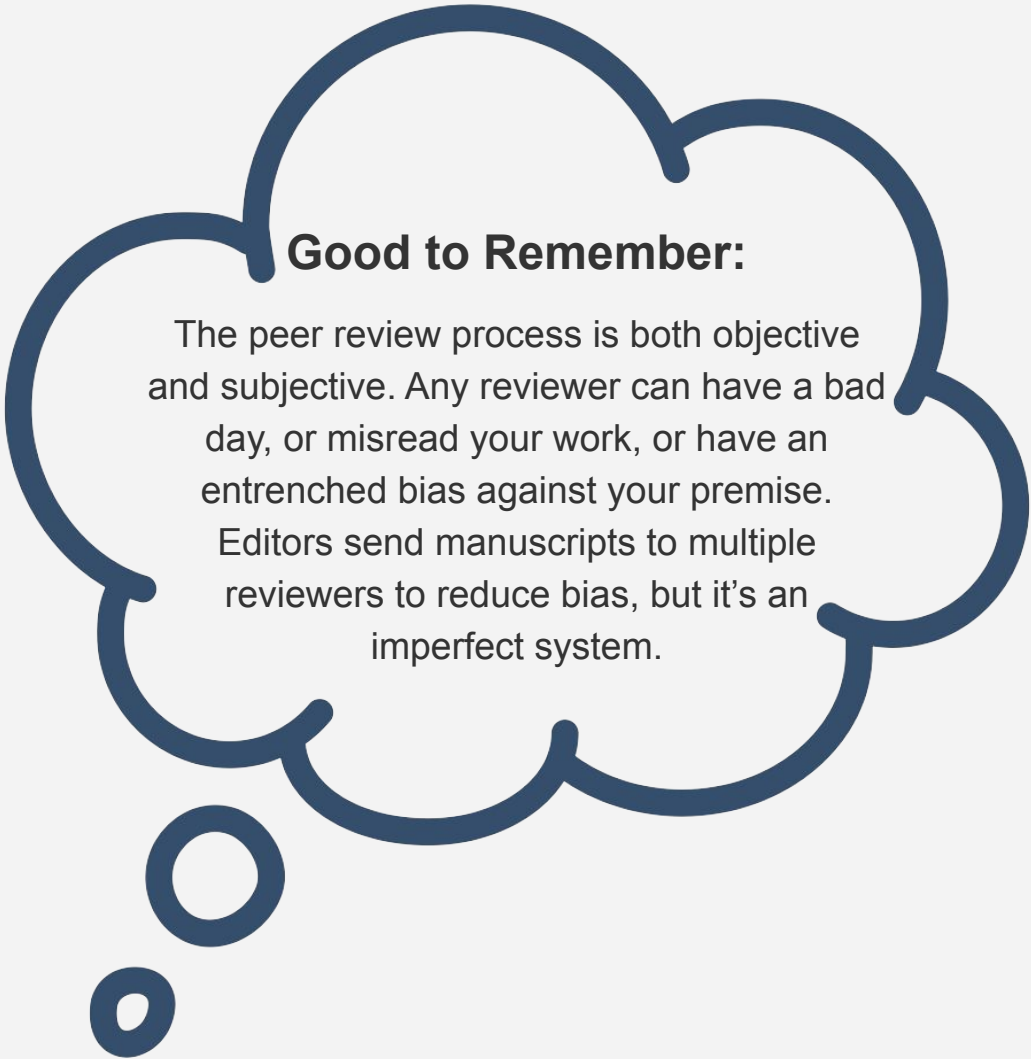
- Review articles from a variety of journals in your discipline
- Read the journal author guidelines
- Ask for feedback first from your local peers/mentors
- Submit a query if the journal accepts them



What are editors and reviewers doing, anyways?

- Initial Review for basic publication requirements:
 - Whether the topic, approach and format matches the scope of the journal
 - Overall impression of substance and style
 - Completeness
- Will help you get to the next round:
 - Clear, cogent writing style
 - Appropriate length
 - Attention to detail: everything from research design to final proofreading needs your close attention.
- Additional considerations:
 - Novelty: originality of thought, counter-intuitive outcomes, new knowledge to add to the field
 - Validity/Soundness of research design





Good to Remember:

The peer review process is both objective and subjective. Any reviewer can have a bad day, or misread your work, or have an entrenched bias against your premise. Editors send manuscripts to multiple reviewers to reduce bias, but it's an imperfect system.

Acceptance: congratulations, you are better than everyone else

- This is the rarest outcome
- You may still have some minor revisions
- Time to celebrate!



Request for Resubmission with Revisions: Major or Minor

Take comments with a grain of salt and retain integrity of your work

- Absorb comments dispassionately
- There may be contradictions
- Look to the editor's cover letter
- You don't have to re-submit



Rejection

- Put it aside for a while
- Focus on the feedback
- Consider revising and submitting to another journal
 - IF it's worth it!
 - Summarize important critiques
- This is part of the process of scholarship



Disciplinary Considerations

- Review takes longer in the Humanities
- Understand conventions around presenting work
- Pre-prints more accepted in the Sciences
- Single author vs. research teams



**Problem:
It isn't objective**



Problem:
**Reviews can vary in
quality and substance**

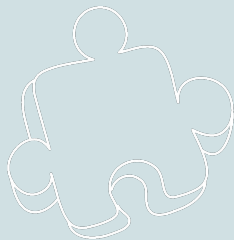


**Problem:
Reviews can conflict
with one another**



**Problem:
Incrementalism vs.
Innovation**





5. Isn't there a better way to do this?

Old and New approaches to peer review

Open Review:

- All identities are communicated and responses may be made publicly available
- Can include Post-Publication Peer Review
- Can be open throughout or in a staged process
- Encourages dialogue/transparency, but still experimental



Varied means of publishing/communicating findings



Concurrent self-archiving

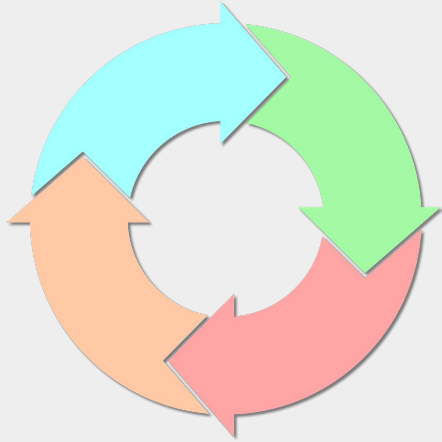
- Authors version appear online at the same time as, or before, publisher's version

Open Access

- Democratization of access allows more to be a part of the conversation, shaping the future of scholarship



Normalize iterative approaches nontraditional feedback mechanisms



Iterative approaches

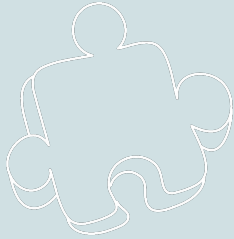
- Errors can be corrected later
- Authors can provide updates/addendums
- Science and scholarship is not “written in stone”

Nontraditional feedback mechanisms

- More informal ways of responding to research findings
- Expanding public scholarship mechanisms



5. Hacking peer review



Before

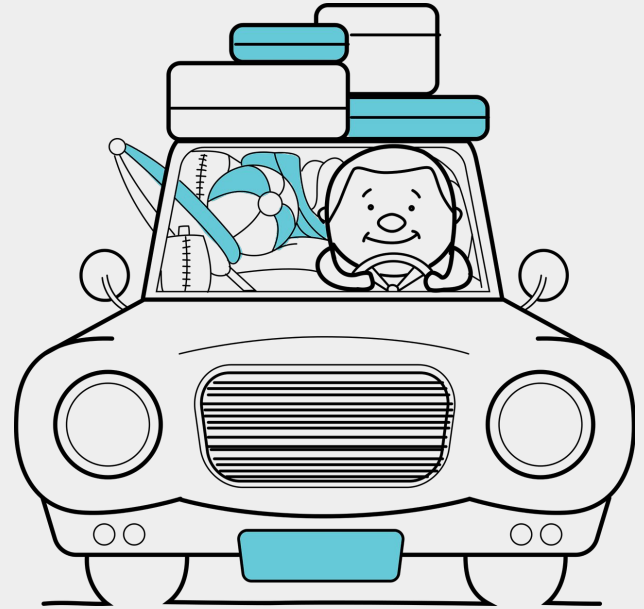
Understand:

- Journal guidelines
- Author responsibilities
- Copyright policies and sharing guidelines



During

- Identify a Contact
- Understand response times
- Consider different angles and next steps



After

Keep track of:

- Timeline for resubmission
- Reviewer comments/concerns
- Your responses and/or justifications

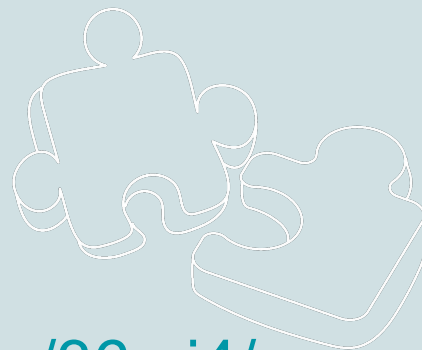
Most importantly...Don't be afraid to ask
for what you need!



Thank you!

Comments? Questions?

Slides posted @ <https://osf.io/36mj4/>



General Questions:
crdds@colorado.edu

Reach me directly
melissa.cantrell@colorado.edu



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Resources

Explainer: What is Peer Review (The Conversation):

<https://theconversation.com/explainer-what-is-peer-review-27797>

Identity in/and Peer Review: Kicking off Peer Review Week 2021 (The Scholarly Kitchen):

<https://scholarlykitchen.sspnet.org/2021/09/20/identity-in-and-peer-review-kicking-off-peer-review-week-2021/>

Study points out evolution of peer review in academic publishing, problems and alternatives (University of Kansas):

<http://news.ku.edu/2021/09/16/study-points-out-evolution-peer-review-academic-publishing-problems-and-alternatives>